

Tamedia Office Building

Shigeru Ban Architects, 2013
Location: Stauffacherquai / Werdstrasse, Zurich, Switzerland| 47° 22' 22" N, 8° 31' 52" E



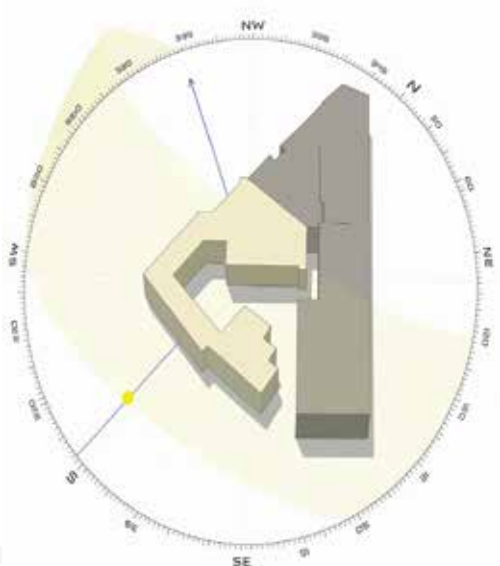
Axon view at sunrise highlighting the glazed enclosure.

DESIGN INTENT

This project reinterprets the conventional office building by utilizing a structure composed entirely of prefabricated, interlocking timber components constructed without steel or metal connectors. Drawing from Japanese wood joinery techniques and locally sourced Austrian spruce, the building’s structure achieves technical innovation and a strong architectural presence, visible from both the interior and exterior. The glass enclosure system is designed to reveal the timber frame, fostering a sense of transparency and openness while serving as a climatic barrier.

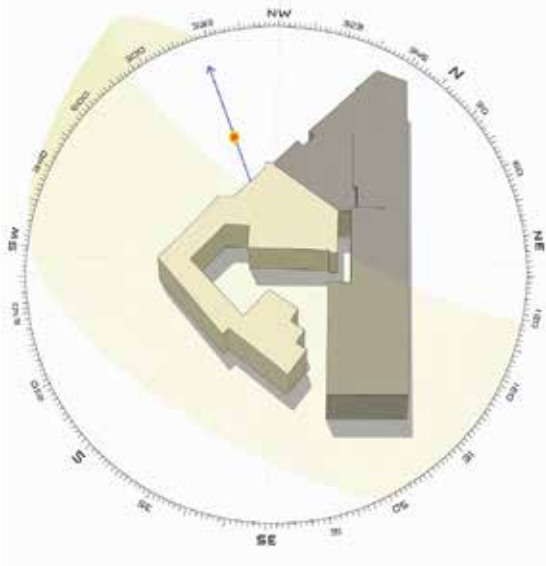
A double façade on the eastern side helps regulate temperature, while retractable windows enable natural ventilation and allow interior spaces to transform into open-air terraces. This “intermediate zone” also serves as a spatial link between floors, shaping circulation and providing informal gathering areas. Facing the city, the fully glazed façade creates a visual dialogue between the building’s interior and the surrounding urban context. The enclosure is a mediator between climate and comfort and a defining element of the building’s identity, defining wood as both a structural and sustainable material.

21 December, 12 PM
Azimuth: 180°
Altitude: 17°



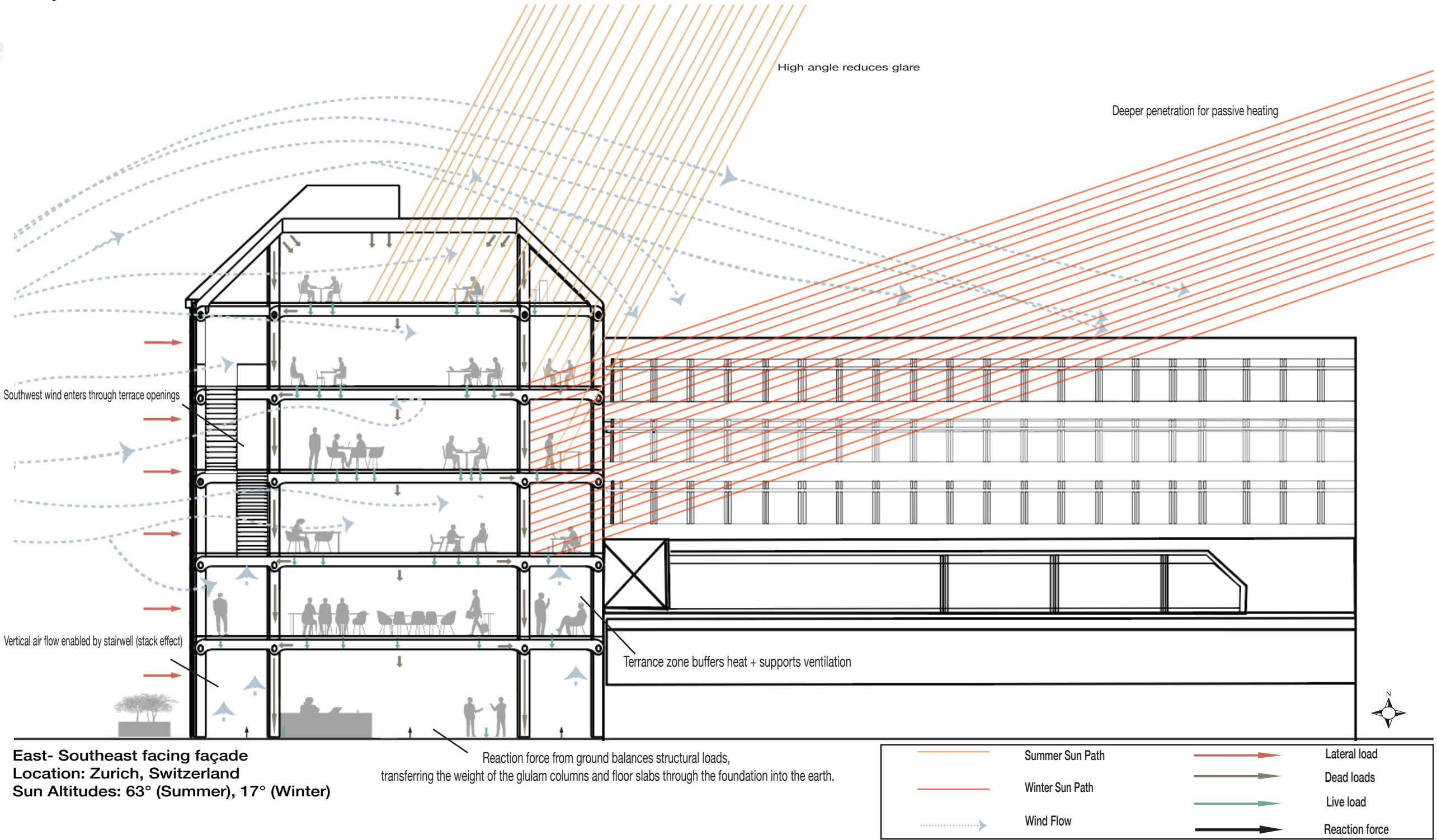
Winter midday sun casts long shadows, but low-angle light penetrates deeply into the glazed enclosure for passive heating.

21 June, 12 PM
Azimuth: 180°
Altitude: 65°



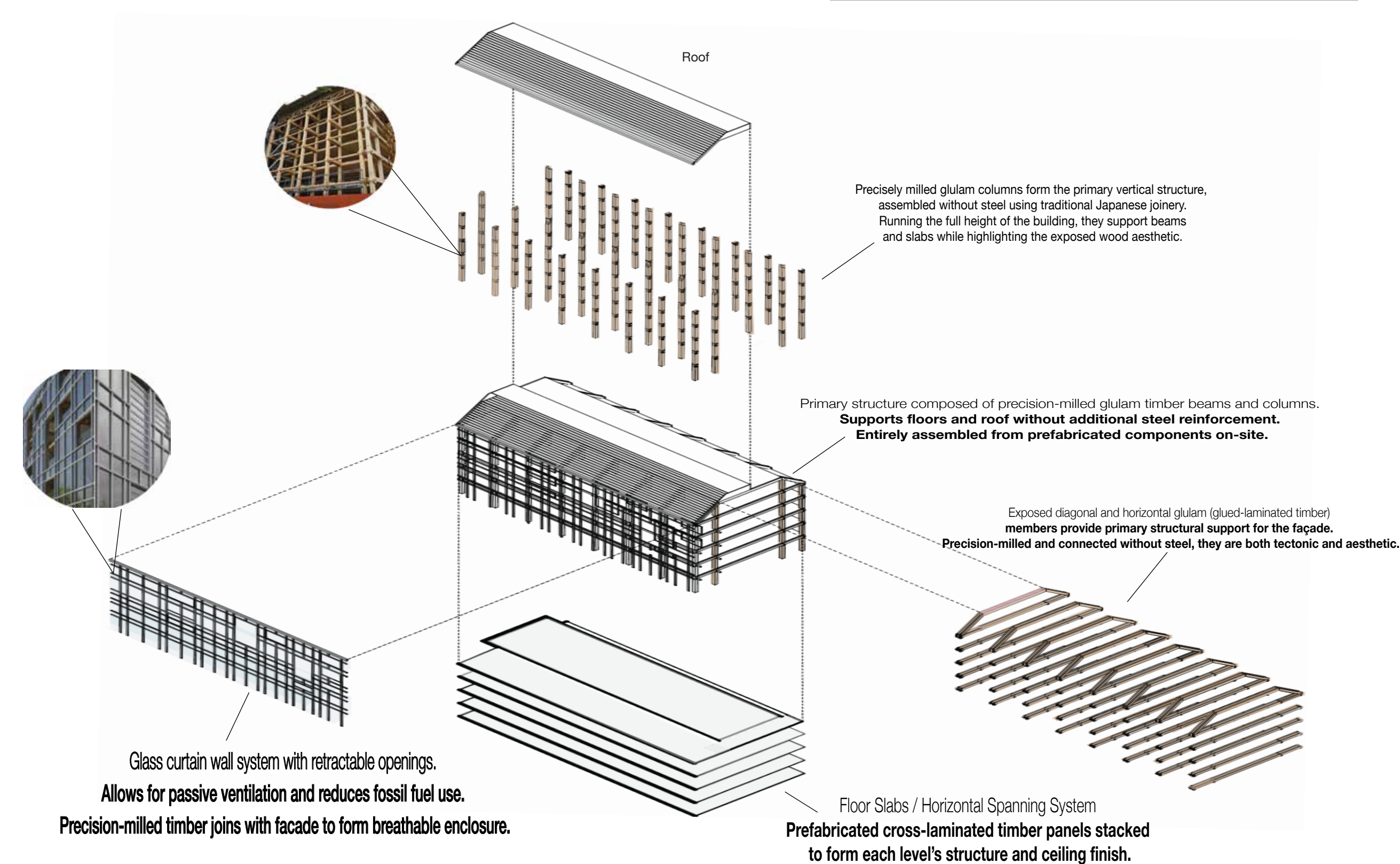
Midday sun during summer creates minimal shadows, maximizing daylight on the terrace zones and upper levels.

Load Distribution + Wind Flow + Sun Path Integration Analysis of Enclosure in Relation to Structure and Climate



East- Southeast facing façade
Location: Zurich, Switzerland
Sun Altitudes: 63° (Summer), 17° (Winter)

Reaction force from ground balances structural loads, transferring the weight of the glulam columns and floor slabs through the foundation into the earth.



Glass curtain wall system with retractable openings.

Allows for passive ventilation and reduces fossil fuel use.

Precision-milled timber joints with facade to form breathable enclosure.

Precisely milled glulam columns form the primary vertical structure, assembled without steel using traditional Japanese joinery. Running the full height of the building, they support beams and slabs while highlighting the exposed wood aesthetic.

Primary structure composed of precision-milled glulam timber beams and columns. Supports floors and roof without additional steel reinforcement. Entirely assembled from prefabricated components on-site.

Exposed diagonal and horizontal glulam (glued-laminated timber) members provide primary structural support for the façade. Precision-milled and connected without steel, they are both tectonic and aesthetic.

Floor Slabs / Horizontal Spanning System

Prefabricated cross-laminated timber panels stacked to form each level's structure and ceiling finish.



View of the Tamedia Office Building's glass façade revealing the timber frame. The enclosure expresses structural logic while creating a transparent relationship with the urban context.



Interior view showcasing natural light entering through the double-glazed façade. The exposed timber frame enhances spatial warmth and visual rhythm.



Detail of the precision-milled timber connection, revealing how the enclosure system integrates structure without the use of metal connectors.

References:

<https://www.shigerubanarchitects.com>
<https://www.archdaily.com>
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<https://www.google.com/maps>